

phone. Of course, don't do this if it's a serious medical emergency! But if you're debating whether or not it's worth making an appointment, give your office a quick call first.

We actually did this during a bout of bad allergies, and because we have such a good relationship with our doctor, he graciously called in a medication for me without the need to go in for an appointment. I was incredibly relieved we didn't have to shell out a \$60 copay!

You can also do this for follow-up appointments. Obviously, this decision is completely up to you and what you feel comfortable with. I'm not telling you not to go, but for me, when it's something minor or the issue is completely gone, I will call and see if I can stay home to avoid another copay. Be sure to check with the doctor first before making a final decision.

READER TIP:

Usually, we don't have to visit if I call and speak with the nurse. Nine times out of ten she tells me my kids will either be fine or what I should give them to help them feel better. We've even had the doctor call in meds without a visit by talking to the nurse. Even after hours many offices have a doctor on call.

—Brittany, MoneySavvyMomma.com

5. INSPECT YOUR BILL

When I worked in the billing department at an OBGYN office, I learned a whole lot about medical billing and coding. I also learned that what the patient pays, or whether or not the claim is even accepted by the insurance company, rests heavily on the coder. That's a lot of pressure!

It's obviously the billing department's responsibility to code your visit properly before submitting any claims, but it's up to you to make sure there's not a mistake. Some doctors will try to "upcode" the visit, meaning they assign it a more serious diagnosis so they get paid more. Sometimes they even submit claims for procedures that weren't even done.